The migration of European colonists to India is usually seen in terms of military and administrative services, but it also included a significant number of traders and entrepreneurs. It was the English East India Company that acquired taxation revenue rights in the 19th century, but it was chiefly Scottish enterprise that dominated British business in India by the end of the 19th century. These migrants were mostly Christians and drawn from Scotland towards Calcutta in the jute, tea and coal sectors. A few of those firms such as Balmer Lawrie, Andrew Yule and Duncans have survived, owned either by the Indian government or migrant business communities such as the Marwaris. Scottish, and more generally European Christian, migration to India for business was very similar to the Indian pattern of temporary settlement, remittance of profits and eventual return to the native place. Just like Indian merchants and entrepreneurs felt the need to cater to the requirements of overseas Indian migrants, European military and administrative presence in India was well served by a similar class of European origin. The first major retail outlets and chains established in India in the late 19th century, such as Spencer's in Madras, arose precisely because of this shopkeeper migration from the 'nation of shopkeepers' to the land of bazaars.[84] Nor was entrepreneurial migration confined to Britain. Larsen & Toubro, one of India's largest engineering firms today, was started by Danish migrants. Monginis, a popular pastry and bakery chain in Mumbai, was started by migrants from Italy.

Apart from Europeans, the Baghdadi Jews were a small but influential business community in India. Initially based in Surat, and later in Bombay and Calcutta, they were Jews from Ottoman Mesopotamia who spoke the Judeo–Arabic language and had roots not only in Baghdad but also in towns such as Basra in Iraq and Aleppo in Syria.[85] State persecution, an age-old method of harassing Jews, led to an initial spurt in migration in the 18th century, thrusting them into the trade routes of the Indian Ocean and the South China Sea. Baghdad-born David Sassoon (1792–1864) started an eponymous firm in the 1830s that would dominate the lucrative textile and opium trades between Britain, India and China, from its base in Bombay. The Sassoons have been labelled the Rothschilds of the East after the